KenTender Module Guide: Departmental Needs

Oct 16, 2026

What Departmental Needs is for

Departmental Needs is the channel through which people in a department say what they expect to need to buy. Each need is one requirement in plain language, with a quantity, a date and an estimated cost. The department's head reviews it, and once accepted it becomes available to Procurement Planning.

It is an optional consultation, not a gate. A department may build its plan entirely from accepted needs, entirely from requirements its head enters directly in Planning, or from both. Accepting a need does not approve spending, reserve money or create a plan item. It only says the requirement is suitable to be considered when the department plans.

What it hands on: accepted needs, each with a named owner and a fixed record of what was asked for and what the head accepted.

Why it matters: public money goes on what the entity actually needs. Every purchase that starts from a need has a confirmed requirement behind it with a named owner, so the entity avoids buying what no department asked for and can show who needed each item and why the quantity is right.

Who uses it

Two responsibilities do the work in Departmental Needs: the Departmental Author states a need, and the Head of User Department decides it. Both are tied to a department, and a department includes its sub-units.

Who	What they can do
Departmental Author	Creates and edits their own need while it is a draft or returned. Submits it, resubmits after a return, and withdraws it while it is still a draft or a returned correction. After acceptance, proposes an update or asks for withdrawal.
Head of User Department	Sees the needs of their department and can create needs for it, which are accepted when the head submits them. Accepts a submitted need, returns it with a reason, or declines to take it forward. Decides proposed updates and withdrawal requests.
Procurement Planner	Reads the current accepted version of a need through Planning, to build the departmental plan. Cannot decide or change a need.
Auditor	Reads needs, their versions, decisions and history across the entity. Changes nothing.
Accounting Officer and Head of Procurement Function	Read needs once they are submitted or decided, but not an author's unsent draft.
System administrators	Can read every record for support. Hold no business authority unless they are assigned it.
Finance, suppliers and bidders	No Departmental Needs work.

A person who holds both roles sees the work of both together, without switching. A job title alone grants nothing. When a head is away, an acting head is given the same responsibility for that department for a stated period. There is no separate delegate role and no extra approval level.

A head of department can create a need for their own department without anyone else's approval: as the head, their need is accepted for planning when they submit it. A head can also enter a requirement straight into the department's plan in Procurement Planning. A need raised by a Departmental Author is always decided by a head, never by the person who submitted it.

What a need contains

One need is one requirement. The Author describes it in plain language and states:

- what is needed, and what the department will be able to do once it has it;
- the quantity and its unit;
- the date it is needed by, within the financial year;
- an estimated cost for the whole requirement, including delivery.

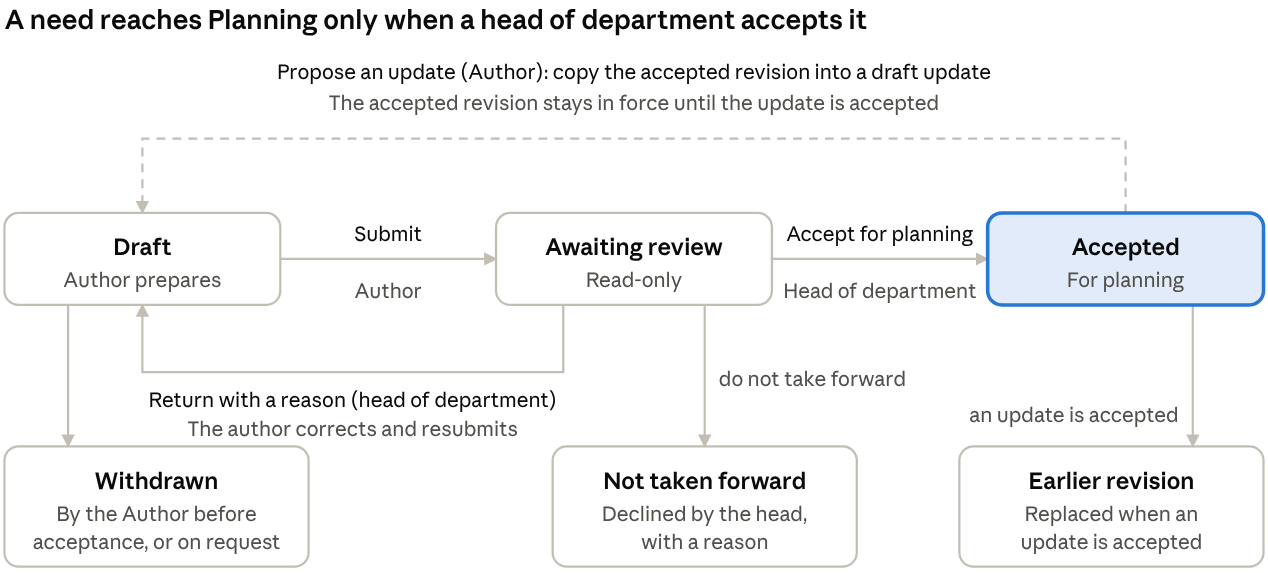
In the laptops purchase. Human Resources Management and Development asks for *Clinical training laptops for digital health rollout*: 100 laptops, estimated at KES 20 million. Digital Health asks for *Clinical deployment laptops for digital health rollout*: 150 laptops, estimated at KES 30 million. The Head of Human Resources returns the training request once to confirm the number of trainees, then accepts it. Digital Health's request is accepted by its acting head while the head is away.

Every need belongs to one department and one financial year, both fixed once it is created. A need keeps numbered **revisions**: the first draft, any returned correction, and any later update to an accepted need. Once a revision is submitted it never changes, and a correction or update starts as a copy.

The estimated cost is a statement of scale, not a funding decision. It names no budget line or funding source and checks no availability. Planning starts the department's own funding estimate from it, and the department can revise that estimate there. A need never records a price per unit, a cost breakdown, a procurement method or an attachment.

How a need moves from draft to accepted

A need is a draft until its Author submits it. A head of department then accepts it, returns it for correction, or declines to take it forward. Accepting is the only route to Planning.



need lifecycle · five states, one loop, one dashed update loop

The journey, step by step:

1. **Draft.** The Author starts a need and fills it in. New needs can be started only while the financial year is open for needs submissions.
2. **Submit.** The system checks that the need is complete, freezes the revision and gives the department's heads one review task. The Author can no longer edit it.
3. **Review.** A head of department who did not submit it sees the whole requirement, including the estimated cost.
4. **Decide.** *Accept for planning* makes the need available to Procurement Planning. *Return for correction* sends it back with a written reason, for the Author to correct and resubmit. *Do not take forward* closes it, also with a reason.
5. **Planning information.** After acceptance, the need's page shows what Planning has done with it: whether the department's plan includes it, and whether it is in the current annual plan. It also says whose turn it is if the department's plan must be updated to carry it. Nothing here changes the need itself.
6. **Update.** To change an accepted need, the Author proposes an update, which copies it into one draft. The accepted revision stays in force. When a head accepts the update, it replaces the earlier revision for new planning and the earlier one is kept as history. A head can instead decline the update, and the accepted revision carries on.
7. **Withdraw.** The Author can ask to withdraw an accepted need, and a head decides. If the need is still in the current annual plan, the request cannot be approved. The Procurement Planner then gets a work item to decide whether the annual plan keeps

the need, and the need's page shows that it is their turn. The request waits until Planning removes the need from the plan, or the head declines it.

If needs submissions close, work in progress survives: drafts and returned corrections can still be edited, and only submitting waits until submissions reopen. A need can have only one open update or withdrawal request at a time.

What the rest of the system takes from accepted needs

Procurement Planning is the only consumer. It takes the current accepted revision of a need exactly as accepted and cannot edit, split or enlarge it. Departmental Needs never reads Planning's records, and it never decides anything for Planning. The two exchange facts in both directions.

Direction	What passes	Effect
Needs to Planning	When a head accepts a need, the accepted facts: reference, revision, title, description, expected result, quantity, unit, required-by date and estimated cost	The need becomes one entry in the department's plan. The department's funding estimate for that entry starts from the need's estimated cost, and the department may revise it. Planning never writes the need's own estimate.
Needs to Planning	An update accepted, or a withdrawal approved	Planning is told which revision replaced which, so it can refresh the department's plan. Earlier approved plans keep the revision they were approved with.
Planning to Needs	Whether the need is in the current annual plan	The need page shows **Included** or **Not included**, for the exact revision shown. An earlier revision still in the plan is named.
Planning to Needs	The outcome when Procurement accepts the department's plan	The need page shows that the department's plan includes it, or that it is not proceeding this year, with the recorded reason.

Direction	What passes	Effect
Planning to Needs	Where the need stands against the department's plan	If the plan was accepted before the need, the page says whose turn it is and offers a link to update the plan.

These Planning facts are shown read-only on the need page and never become a status of the need. A need that is left out of a plan this year is still accepted, and a need that appears in the annual plan is not marked as used up.

A need is optional, and a department can also plan requirements its head enters directly in Planning. Those create no need and need no review here.

Safeguards

- **Authority comes from assignment, within a department.** Authors and heads act only for the departments, and their sub-units, they are assigned to. A job title alone grants nothing, and an acting head is assigned for a stated period.
- **Authors do not decide their own needs.** An Author's need is decided by a head, never by the person who submitted it. A head's own need is accepted when the head submits it.
- **Submitted revisions never change.** A head cannot edit a need: a wrong figure is corrected by returning it. Corrections and updates always start as a new revision.
- **Acceptance is not funding.** Accepting a need creates no plan item, reserves no money and starts no requisition or tender.
- **Approved plans are not rewritten.** An accepted update does not change a plan already approved with the earlier revision, and a need still in the current annual plan cannot be withdrawn.
- **History is kept.** Every submission, return, decision and withdrawal is recorded with who acted, in what role, when and why.